

Q Will my relationship with my partner change forever with a baby around? How do we adapt?

There is no doubt that having a baby around will change the current dynamic of your relationship, but that in itself can have positive rewards.

It's normal to feel concerned about the impending changes ahead and worry that you may lose something of the precious intimacy you currently enjoy. Whether you have planned this baby or not—and even if you feel a sense of contentment about creating a family—your relationship with your partner will inevitably need to evolve as you become parents.

It's a good idea to define the feelings you have about a change in your relationship and becoming parents. If your relationship is strong, take heart from the fact that you already understand the process of getting to know each other, learning about each other's qualities and character so you can relate to one another and support and nurture each other in life.

Talk to each other

It's important that you find time to talk about issues on your minds. These may include worries about spending less time with each other after the birth, and maybe more time with your in-laws; the changes in your roles and how to manage household tasks; moving from two wages to one (even if it's only temporary) and the sense of dependence or pressure this may bring; and personal expectations about how you want to parent your baby.

If you worry about becoming parents, be reassured that it's not as difficult as you think. You will adapt to your roles, but give yourselves time. Researchers have estimated that it takes new parents at least four months to establish a routine and feel confident with their baby.

Keep **communicating** openly and **showing respect** to each other as you prepare for, and then **parent**, your child.

DISCUSSION POINTS

Talk through your expectations of life as a family so you understand each other's hopes and feelings and know how to keep your relationship a priority once you become parents.



Q I feel stressed. Will the baby be affected?

It's perfectly natural to feel anxious about how you will cope with life—and a baby. There probably isn't a woman who hasn't felt worried, anxious, inadequate, or even fearful at some point during her first (or subsequent) pregnancy. Bringing a new life into the world is a magical time, but it's also one filled with unpredictability and change. And if you work or lead a busy life, the prospect of trying to process all you need to do before the birth can sometimes feel incredibly pressured.

If you feel stressed, your body produces higher levels of the hormone cortisol. Research is still being conducted as to whether prolonged bouts of cortisol affect your unborn baby: some studies have shown that the effects of chronic

stress on a fetus can be minimal; others that constant stress may put your baby at risk. We all experience stress at various times, but it's important that you don't let it overwhelm you. Try to live in the moment, learn to delegate and don't attempt to do everything yourself, rest when you can, and exercise moderately—it's a great way to release stress.

If your stress has turned into anxiety and you feel you can't cope, have no appetite, you're worried about going out, you cry much of the time, and feel lethargic and uninterested in life, you may have prenatal depression (PND). Although less well known than postpartum depression (see p.263), it probably affects more women than we realize simply because moms-to-be often feel ashamed of and are afraid to mention their negative feelings. If you're at all concerned, talk to your doctor, as well as your family and/or friends.

Q I am excited about our baby, but my partner isn't. How can I get my partner more enthused?

It seems obvious, but make an effort to involve your partner in as many ways as possible.

Encourage your partner to feel your belly often, for example, and talk to your baby: around 24 weeks gestation the fetus begins to hear what's going on outside the uterus. Also consider whether what you see as lack of enthusiasm may in fact be anxiety about your partner's responsibilities, so ask your partner how they are feeling. Finally, while pregnancy is a living part of you, for your partner there's probably something a bit unreal about it. Hang in there; for many partners, full and enthusiastic engagement happens only when finally they hold their baby in their arms.